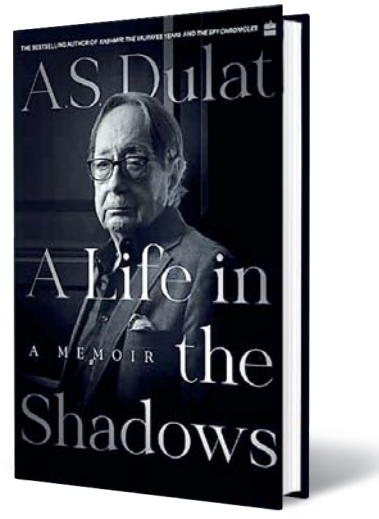
BOOKS

NOTES FROM A SPYMASTER

By T.C.A. Raghavan



A LIFE IN THE SHADOWS: A MEMOIR
by A.S. Dulat
HARPERCOLLINS
₹699; 264 pages

Amarjit Singh Dulat's *A Life in the Shadows: A Memoir* is only in part about his life. He does discuss his career in the Intelligence Bureau (IB), then as head of the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) and, finally, post-retirement, as advisor on Jammu & Kashmir in the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) till May 2004, when the National Democratic Alliance (NDA)-I demitted office. He also goes into his family background, early life, school and college, and joining the Indian Police Service. But the meat of the book is Kashmir. This is what holds the author's greatest attention and he talks about his assessments of the role of the intelligence community in dealing with what happens to be India's most intractable internal security challenge with all its external ramifications in some detail.

Dulat's Kashmir interface began in 1988. Soon after his arrival in Srinagar came the crisis of 1989-90, the forced exodus of the Hindu minority, the kidnapping of the Union home minister's daughter and the conditions of near-breakdown of the administrative machinery in general. Dulat's memory of it is this: "'The IB knew nothing of what was happening on the ground at the time. It was an intelligence failure at our end." He also writes, "I remember being out of my depth in an unfamiliar situation. Everything was happening too fast and far too quickly."

He deals more briefly with what are generally regarded as other major intelligence failures: Kargil and the attack on Parliament, although he devotes some pages to the IC-814 hijack. This, however, is ground that he has covered, as indeed are the events of 1989-90 in Kashmir, in his earlier memoir on his time in the PMO dealing with Kashmir. The thrust of this book is more reflective and is a discourse on his approach to Kashmir, a spelling out of what he regards as his tradecraft and, finally, an implied, sometimes upfront, critique of present policy.

His preference is clearly stated: "counter-intelligence", by which he means turning opponents around by engagement. It also came to represent a policy of dialogue with different elements in Kashmir, including separatists and militants. Counter-intelligence as a skill has, in his telling, lost both its cutting edge and the elan surrounding it; it has yielded ground to "counter-terrorism". This is an instrument Dulat sees as sometimes necessary but ultimately limited; "force never wipes out insurgency," he approvingly quotes an authority as saying.

Counter-intelligence as an approach, he notes, however, always had a rough ride with the Indian intelligence fraternity, who saw it as too "soft" an option. The reason for this, he argues at one stage, is Pakistan, "which lies at the heart of the paranoia". This is the main engine for the "mistrust, the lack of imagination and the absolute convention that governs much of the espionage game in Kashmir". In his view, distancing oneself from anything associated with Pakistan undermines intelligence functioning because this cuts you off from information.

For Dulat, the essence of good tradecraft is that the espionage community has to see the world differently from, say, politicians or civil servants. For him then, the real problem is that "Delhi has seen things only in black and white". In difficult areas, "that doesn't work": Kashmir, in particular, is "mostly grey and constantly in need of empathy, compassion and compromise".

It's evident that this engagement-underwritten tradecraft is considerably at variance with current policy. Dulat sees "the new muscular policy" with its different dimensions of non-engagement, the abrogation of Article 370, etc., as a "failure" as it is leading to a "radicalisation" of Kashmir. Somewhat unusually, he devotes a chapter to the current National Security Advisor—also an old Intelligence Bureau hand—to underline the contrast between current and past approaches.

Beyond personalities, the issues that are revealed in Dulat's treatment are certainly insightful in developing a better understanding of the national security challenges that bedevil us.

Dulat notes at one point that every secret service "tends to mythologise itself". And perhaps the secret universe of espionage is particularly prone to that. Certainly, *A Life in the Shadows* falls in that tradition even as it shines a light into this opaque world. ■

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